



DELHI | No Division Needed

Independent India's first home minister Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel had ended the practice of a caste-based census in the country, saying "it would lead to divisiveness". Dismissing that idea this week, a renewed call for a caste-based census arose in Parliament from all parties, stalling the Lok Sabha twice. The demand first came from the Congress' own backyard six months ago with Law Minister Veerappa Moily writing to Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, asking for a caste-based enumeration along with the census. The Social Justice Ministry had also asked for caste to be included as a criterion in the 2011 census and recommended a differential headcount of the Other Backward Classes (OBC) as well as a reassessment of their conditions that could lead to changes in the OBC list. What came as a surprise was the overwhelming support the idea received from virtually every political party from the BJP to the Left, the Shiromani Akali Dal to the Shiv Sena, the AIADMK to the DMK and the Yadav parties. The Government has rejected the demand but its reasoning was more semantic and bureaucratic, not at all about the "idea of divisiveness". The last caste-based data came from the 1931 census, with Moily saying the Centre did not have caste-based data of its own. "Now the census (2011) has started and formats are being finalised. So how it would be done now?" That may not be the last word.

by Shafi Rahman

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years after the last caste-based census, parties across the spectrum sought one again last week in Parliament.

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